was in the Soviet Union for some time. But linguistically nothing could be done with him.

22

Edith failed to convince Erich to visit Wiebelskirchen when his brother, Robert, returned from years in British captivity in the Egyptian desert. Having contracted Schistosomiasis, an infection caused by a parasitic worm in the blood, Robert was left drained. After spending several months bedridden, he died on 30 October 1947. Too full of grief for his brother, Erich could not bring himself to attend the funeral.

At this time, he was focused on establishing the Young Pioneers Association in the FDJ, which launched to a barrage of criticism from parents demanding children should be shielded from politics. ‘We were of a different opinion,’ Honecker explained. ‘As early as at the age of 10, I saw that children were confronted with politics. They were either with the workers or with those who were against the workers.’ He preached that imparting state ideology to schoolchildren was essential in order to ‘convey the feeling of social responsibility to them’.23

With this in mind, Honecker was also busily improving Junge Welt, the central organ of the FDJ, which was morphing into a considerable success.24 Behind the scenes, Edith used her contacts to procure interviews, and help compose Honecker’s opinion pieces – which evolved a style like that of Russian periodicals. There was no luxuriance of rhetoric, his articles were stuffed with atrocious technical terms outside of the ordinary lexicon, such as: classless society, peasantry, bourgeois, capitalist and Narodnik. From here on, this became the distinctive Honecker tone – blunt, factual and without creativity or emotion. Although hardly a marvel of journalism, Honecker insisted Junge Welt was committed to ‘progressive democracy’ and exposing ‘all those who, under the guise of democracy, are hostile to young people’.25 Over the coming decades its circulation thrived and even exceeded one million, making it the most widely read newssheet, even outselling Neues Deutschland, its only real national competitor.